



THE SUMERIANS

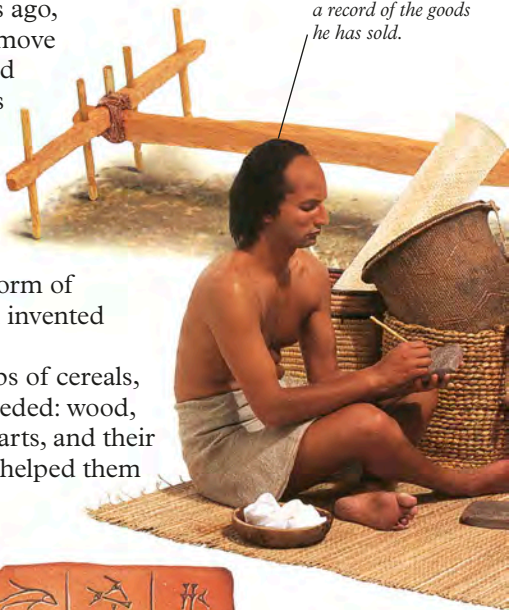


About 9,000 years ago, farmers began to move into an area of land between the Tigris

and Euphrates rivers. This fertile land was called Mesopotamia, in what is now Iraq. In the south of Mesopotamia was the land of Sumer. The Sumerians were very inventive. They developed the first form of writing and recording numbers, and invented the wheel and the plow.

The Sumerians grew bumper crops of cereals, which they traded for things they needed: wood, building stone, or metals. Wheeled carts, and their skills in writing and using numbers, helped them develop long-distance trade.

A merchant makes a record of the goods he has sold.



How writing began

The Sumerians drew pictures on soft clay with a pointed reed. The pictures were drawn downward in lines, from the right-hand side.



Fish

Bird

Barley

Ox



The signs were then joined together to create words and sentences.



Later, they started to write across the tablet, from left to right. The reed tip made wedge-shaped marks.

In time, the picture signs changed so much that the original objects were hard to recognize. This writing is called cuneiform, which means "wedge-shaped."

